

TOMATO PRICES

MANISH RAJPUT

TOUGH TO SWALLOW

By M.G. Arun

Consumers are used to seasonal changes in the prices of vegetables, but this one was particularly hard to stomach. In a matter of just two months, retail prices of tomatoes soared to Rs 200 a kg in several parts of the country from as low as Rs 30 a kg in May, compelling many to cut down their consumption or take it totally off the household menu. With tomato prices hitting the headlines, the Centre stepped in to make the vegetable available at subsidised rates to consumers in some states, but those in the farm sector believe that only a move to higher production will offer any respite from soaring prices. That again is fraught with challenges, given that the delayed monsoon and floods in many parts of the country have destroyed newly planted crops.

In India, tomato is cultivated as a rabi crop (usually sown in mid-November or December and harvested in April-May) in parts of Maharashtra, Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh. However, in some parts of Maharashtra such as Nashik, and states like Uttar Pradesh, it is sown as a